has an aggressive OBC leader, Bandi Sanjay Kumar, leading the state even as it keeps busy poaching from the TRS and Congress. Nadda was in the state again in August for a rally in Warangal, at the end of the third phase of Bandi's statewide 'praja sangrama' yatra.

In poll-bound states, the BJP pushes the '*saksham mandal, sakriya booth, panna pramukh* (self-reliant mandals, active booth, page head)' strategy. Besides consolidating a rainbow support base of castes, the BJP is eyeing the bottom of the pyramid: the 330 million-strong *labharthis* (beneficiaries of 16 central schemes) as a crucial new support base.

COMMUNITY OUTREACH

In the run-up to 2024, the BJP is also trying to cultivate communities for whom they are traditionally not the natural choice. Choosing Droupadi Murmu as the country's first tribal president is of a piece with this thinking. Tribals make up 9 per cent of the electorate nationally and the BJP hopes elevating one from among them to the top post has created goodwill for the party. "Our presence and hold in these areas is declining day by day. We need to establish a strong connection," a top BJP leader had told the leadership at a meeting in New Delhi a month or so before Murmu became president. Poaching senior tribal leader Ashwin Kotwal, the party's latest acquisition from the Congress in Gujarat, was part of this agenda. Besides, the BJP is mending fences with the tribal community in MP, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan. Polls are due in all four states—the Congress had won 86 of the 128 ST reserved seats here in 2017-18.

In Chhattisgarh, long-serving ex-CM Raman Singh seems to have lost the leadership's confidence, and they are actively seeking leaders from the tribal communities. There's also a buzz over Congress rebel and ex-royal T.S. Singh Deo switching sides. The BJP thinks the road to recovery lies in the rural plains of the state dominated by the Sahu community; hence its new OBC state unit chief Arun Sao. In MP, CM Chouhan too is focusing on the OBCs and tribal areas. The 15.3 million-strong tribal population makes up 21 per cent of the electorate. Of the 47 assembly seats reserved for them, the BJP managed only 16 in 2018. RSS organisations like the Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh and Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram are trying to leverage their hold among the tendu leaf-pickers and the beedi-rolling cottage industry. The outfits have also put pressure on Union health minister Mansukh Mandaviya to abandon the controversial amendments in the Cigarette and Other Tobacco Products Act. MP is also working to connect 827 forest villages to the rest of the state. The Chouhan government has also set aside 20 per cent of the revenues from the forests for tribal welfare. As for the 48 per cent OBC electorate, the party was quick to react to the 2022 apex court judgment scrapping reservations for them in the local body polls. A review petition has been filed. Even with all this, there could be trouble in store, especially as the party plans to implement the 'one family, one ticket' rule, leaving a number of leaders in a sulk.

The Jats are a constituency that, in terms of its romance with the BJP, has been on again and off again. Naming Jagdeep Dhankhar as vice-president—the first Jat leader to grace the office—is meant to be an outreach to a community spread across Punjab, Haryana, Rajasthan and western UP, a wide cross-section of which holds a grudge against the party's handling of the farmers' protests last year. Assembly polls are due in Rajasthan next year and Jats make up 12 per cent of the electorate there.

TACKLING DISSENT

The dilemma for the BJP is whether it should project ex-CM Vasundhara Raje as the campaign leader again. The central leadership is not her biggest fan, but it's also true that no BJP leader can rival her stature in the state. Raje seems to be back in the reckoning, even getting to announce the '*har ghar tiranga yatra*' at a crucial presser during the national executive meeting.

Then there is the growing dissent. As is natural for any national party with such a wide footprint, the BJP too is battling internal factions and camps in most states. In Himachal Pradesh, Union minister Anurag Thakur is becoming ambitious and there are at least three factions vying for a piece of the action. In Karnataka, CM Bommai is yet to get a grip on the party and the government, which has led to other Lingayat leaders such as Nirani Murugesh, Arvind Bellad and Jagdish Shettar flexing their muscles. In Gujarat and MP, besides intra-party tussles, the BJP will also have to deal with the heartburn from accommodating a large number of Congress turncoats.

In Gujarat, the party has been in power for close to three decades, and the Congress thinks it has a legitimate chance of ending the BJP's reign. There is also the added challenge from the Aam Aadmi Party, which has a spring

ZEROING IN ON LS SEATS



BIHAR

LS seats: **40**
BJP*: **17**
Focus seats: **16**

STRATEGY

- Deploy ex-deputy CM Sushil Modi back in state to attack Nitish Kumar
- Corner RJD on corruption-related issues
- Rework alliance with Chirag Paswan faction of LJP, Mukesh Sahani's VIP

CHALLENGES

- OBC survey data may come in Feb. '23, could disrupt caste equations
- If Muslim votes link up with OBC castes, it will hit BJP chances



PUNJAB

LS seats: **13**
BJP: **2**
Focus seats: **9**

STRATEGY

- Build up party in rural belt
- Poach leaders from Congress, Akali Dal, integrate them into party framework
- Build bridges with Sikh organisations

CHALLENGES

- Residual anger from farm law protests
- BJP isn't seen as an alternative; ex-ally Akali Dal in meltdown
- Rise of fringe elements in rural Punjab

*LS seats in 2019